

Chapter

Marriage — Not Taking, but Giving



Introduction: The Biggest Misunderstanding

Most people regard marriage as a means of getting happiness — "Now I am married, now I will get happiness, I will get love." In this short excerpt from a discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji turns this very notion upside down: **marriage is not for taking, it is for giving**. And the karma we do in marriage is not a trade, but a means of **chitta-shuddhi** — purification of the mind.

Kartavya-karma — action done as one's dharma and responsibility, without expectation of its fruit. **Prarabdh** — the fruit of past karmas that is to be lived out in this life.

Marriage Is Not a Business

Acharya Ji begins with a common way of thinking — and immediately shows the illusion in it:

"'I am married, so my husband should give me love; it is his duty.' Actually, **but asking for love is not my duty. She did not come to do business.**"

"So many people feel that marriage means I have to go there to become happy. **It is a very big misunderstanding.**"

What is the result of this misunderstanding?

"Both feel — we are married, now I have become happy — **and they live unhappily all their lives.** The reason is, because they forgot that **this marriage was not about taking, it was about giving.**"

Giving What You Have

So what is to be given? Acharya Ji says — whatever you have, whatever talent you have. For the wife:

"Whatever you know, whatever talent you have — she is a girl, so she knows how to cook; if she knows how to earn something. Its description is there: **in friendship, becoming his minister, through conversation, doing some planning, she gives that too.**"

"Pleasure of intimacy has also been mentioned — her role in the bedroom, that has been mentioned too. **She has different roles.** Cooking — like a mother, she also has to cook and give him food."

(Here Acharya Ji points to the traditional description of a wife's roles — as minister, mother, friend and companion.)

But what is the purpose of all these roles?

"But all these karmas she was to do **for her own purification, only for the sake of doing.**"

And the same applies equally to the husband:

"And the husband also had to. If I know how to earn, I can do something more; I like to travel, so **I have to take her travelling too**; I can provide some protection — or whatever his task will be."

I Am Born to Give

From here Acharya Ji takes the subject of marriage to a basic principle of life:

"**I am born to give, not to take.** The karma I will do now will be my kartavya-karma."

"It is only for the purification of the chitta, **it is not for trade.** That something will come to me out of it — it is not for that at all. **That attainment of the Real comes from something else.** It has been said — 'vastu-upalabdhi vichāra-mātreṇa.'"

Here Acharya Ji points to this famous principle from Adi Shankaracharya's Vivekachudamani:

cittasya śuddhaye karma na tu vastūpalabdhaye
vastusiddhir vicāreṇa na kiñcit karmakoṭibhiḥ
"Action is for the purification of the mind, not for
the attainment of the Real. The Real is attained
through inquiry, not in the least through millions of
actions."

— Vivekachudamani 11

That is, every duty performed in marriage is also, in this sense, a means of purifying the mind.

Marriage Also Needs Reflection and Knowledge

Along with action, reflection is also needed — and one has to do that reflection oneself:

"'This wife is a goddess, I am making her happy, she has become happy' — **all this, too, you yourself have to reflect upon.** Then I also have to gain knowledge of what is to be done in marriage."

"There is a woman — what does a woman mean, what is she like? What will a woman's qualities be? **Trying to understand that, perhaps 27 births will go by, but he will not understand** — so says Acharya Chanakya too."

"Everything is taught, but what a woman is, and her mind — that is a little difficult to understand. **One does not understand even one's own mind, so understanding a woman's mind is extremely difficult.** He said — don't even get into that. Chanakya Ji says so; it is not I who am saying it."

Understanding a Woman's Nature

Even if you cannot understand fully, you should at least have this much knowledge — that a woman's nature is different from a man's:

"But understand that she is a woman. You will understand this much, won't you — she is a woman, so she will be fickle, sometimes there will be emotional drama, **she will live on the level of the mind.**"

"You understand this much: **if you live on body-awareness or on the awareness of the intellect, you can remain tough.** For her, it becomes just like a page of history — so much crying, she will remember everything of hers from all over the world."

"So you know — **so there should be this much knowledge of how she should be treated,** that she is delicate, what she is like."

On top of this, one must also know one's wife's nature:

"Is my wife **rajasic, or tamasic, or sattvic?** What is her desire? One comes to understand this even at the time of marriage."

Prarabdh and a New Decision

Finally, Acharya Ji places marriage in the larger picture of karma. What kind of partner you got — that is past karma; what you do with them — that is new karma:

"Whether I am giving her this or not — that is my karma for becoming pure. I got a nagging one, a quarrelsome one — that is my past prarabdh."

"Now what I do with her — she came for the cutting of my karma. Now whether to give a divorce or to live with love — that can be my new decision, a new thought."

"Is this much understood? Finally, it will drop down to vichāra-mātra — to reflection alone."

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Marriage is not a business — asking for love is not one's duty; giving is the duty.
- 2 "Marriage will make me happy" — this is a very big misunderstanding, and it is why people stay unhappy all their lives.

- 3 Give whatever talent and ability you have — the wife in her roles, the husband in earning, taking her travelling and protection.
- 4 I am born to give, not to take. Kartavya-karma is for the purification of the mind, not for trade.
- 5 "Cittasya śuddhaye karma" — action purifies the mind; the attainment of the Real comes through inquiry.
- 6 Marriage also needs knowledge — a woman lives on the level of the mind; one must understand how to treat her.
- 7 The partner you got is your past prarabdh; how you live with them is a new decision — and in the end everything comes down to reflection alone.